



THE EL NIÑO SEASON PREP LIST

A Historic Winter Is Coming. Here's How To Be Ready.

Forecasters are calling this El Niño potentially the strongest on record. That doesn't mean panic, it means prep, and this is everything you actually need, not just "have some food and water on hand."

>90%

VERY STRONG EL NIÑO
this fall & winter

75%

ODDS IT'S HISTORIC
strongest since 1950

Jan-Mar

PEAK RAIN WINDOW
above-normal Dec-Apr

What's Actually Happening

Here's the real read, not just the scary headline — and what it means specifically if you're near Eaton or Palisades.

01

The Forecast

- NOAA's own Sept 10 diagnostic puts this at **>90% odds** of a "very strong" El Niño this fall and winter
- 75% odds it becomes the strongest event on record since 1950 — LA County's own briefings are calling it historic
- Above-normal rain expected December through April, heaviest stretch January through March

HISTORIC

02

Worth Knowing

- A strong ocean signal doesn't guarantee LA actually gets soaked
- 2015-16 was the strongest El Niño signal ever measured, and downtown LA still finished *below* average that year
- Real, well-forecast risk worth taking seriously — not a guaranteed disaster

THE HONEST PART

03

If You're Near Eaton Or Palisades

- Both burn scars are still inside their ~2-year window where the soil stays water-repellent
- USGS puts Palisades-area canyons at **60-80% debris-flow odds** under a real storm; Eaton rates **"high"**
- The trigger is small: about a quarter inch of rain in 15 minutes, an ordinary rate

READ THIS ONE TWICE

FROM JULIA

I'm not trying to scare anyone into a bunker mentality here. I just know from being in these neighborhoods every week that the people who fare best in a real storm aren't the ones who panicked, they're the ones who did the boring stuff early. Gutters, sandbags, a flashlight that actually has batteries in it.

THE FULL CHECKLIST

Everything you do.
Grouped the way you actually tackle it.

The One Everyone Misses

Property & Insurance

- ☐ Clear gutters, downspouts, and storm drains
- ☐ Get sandbags before storms arrive
They genuinely run out once a storm's in the news
- ☐ Flood insurance takes 30+ days to activate — can't buy it storm week
- ☐ Repair known roof leaks now, not mid-storm
- ☐ Flood damage isn't covered by standard homeowners insurance — it's a separate policy

WATER & FOOD

- ☐ 1 gallon, per person, per day, minimum 3 days.
FEMA's real target is 2 weeks if you have the space
- ☐ A manual can opener, plus shelf-stable basics: crackers, peanut butter, canned beans and chicken
- ☐ Got little kids? Skip the health-food guilt trip and pack it like a picnic — whatever they'll actually eat without a fight
- ☐ Canned fruit is worth grabbing too (peaches, pineapple, mandarin oranges)
Not an everyday food, but real nutrition matters when you're stuck inside with nothing to do
- ☐ Unopened fridge: ~4 hrs. Full freezer: ~48 hrs, ~24 if half full.
Source: USDA — every door-open resets the clock

LIGHT, POWER & SIGNAL

- ☐ Headlamps over candles — open flame in a power-out house is a bad call, especially with burn-scar fire risk still fresh
- ☐ A battery or crank lantern per room, plus a charged power bank for phones
- ☐ Generator: 20 ft from the house, exhaust away, never in a garage
Source: CPSC — carbon monoxide too close is a real, fatal risk
- ☐ Battery-backup CO alarms on every level
- ☐ A battery or crank NOAA weather radio, plus offline maps downloaded before, not during

MEDICAL, CASH & PETS

- ☐ 7-14 days of any prescription, refilled ahead, plus a backup power plan for medical devices
- ☐ Cash in small bills
Card readers and ATMs need power too
- ☐ Copies of ID, insurance, and key documents, waterproofed or backed up digitally
- ☐ Gas tank at least half full through storm season
Pumps run on electricity
- ☐ Pet food, water, meds, and a carrier staged and ready

The Week Before A Storm Hits

SECTION 04

- ☐ Charge every device and power bank you own

☐ Fill water containers and top off the gas tank

☐ Move valuables off the ground floor if you're flood-prone

☐ Know your evacuation route if you're below a burn scar

IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER THREE THINGS

01

INSURANCE

Flood coverage is separate from homeowners and takes 30+ days to kick in. Check it today.

02

BURN SCARS

A quarter inch of rain in 15 minutes is all it takes on fresh burn scar. Know your route now.

03

POWER OUTAGE

Fridge: ~4 hours. Freezer: ~48 hours. Keep both closed as long as you can.

FROM JULIA

However this winter goes, you don't have to figure it out alone. Storm prep, insurance questions, whether your specific street has ever flooded before you bought there, this is the kind of thing I talk through with clients all year, not just when the forecast gets scary. Reach out any time.

Sources: NOAA Climate Prediction Center (Sept 10, 2026) · Ready LA County · USGS Landslide Hazards Program · USDA FoodSafety.gov · Ready.gov/FEMA · U.S. CPSC

EL NIÑO FIELD GUIDE

Winter 2026–27

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I've Got You

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